

CELTIC AND SAXON mythology were the two great groups from which most people in the British Isles descended. Tolkien had great love for the story telling traditions of the bold warrior race, the Saxons but he was also vividly aware that these rough Teutonic warriors supplanted the older, more sophisticated Celtic civilization and its fluid language and poetry.

Celtic mythology has played a fundamental part in the shaping of Tolkien's world. His most important source was the *Red Book of Hergest* which is a manuscript that includes the most important compendium of Welsh legends, *The Mabinogion*.

This collection has many stories of magic rings. The damsel Luned, the Lady of the fountain, gives a Ring of invisibility to the hero Owain. Lyonesse gives her hero Gareth a magical ring that will not allow him to be wounded. And Percival Long Spear goes on a quest for a gold ring during which he slays the Black serpent of the Barrows and wins a stone of invisibility and gold-making stone.

However, the most important aspect of the Celtic influence on Tolkien relates to how much its mythology contributed to the creation of his "Elves". In general terms it is quite easy to see that Tolkien has largely aligned the traditions of the older Celtic peoples with his Elves; while the invading race of Anglo-Saxons have the characteristics of his men.

Tolkien's Elves are largely based on the traditions and conventions of the Celtic myths and legends of Ireland and Wales. However, before Tolkien the 'Elf' was a vaguely defined concept associated most often with pixies, faeries, gnomes, etc. but Tolkien's Elves are a powerful, full-blooded people who closely resemble the pre-human Irish race of immortals called the Tuatha De Danann.

Like the Tuatha De Danann, Tolkien's Elves are taller and stronger than mortals, are incapable of suffering sickness, are possessed of more than human beauty, and are filled with greater wisdom in all things.

They possess Talismans, jewels and weapons that humans might consider magical in their powers. They ride supernatural horses and understand the languages of animals.

The Tuatha De Danann gradually withdrew from Ireland as mortal men migrated from the east. With his ever present theme of the dwindling of Elvish power on Middle Earth, Tolkien was following the tradition of Celtic myth.

The Elves' westward sailings to timeless immortal realms across the sea, leaving the human race behind in a diminished world trapped in time, was very much the theme of the diminishing of the Tuatha De Danann.

The remnant of this once mighty race was the 'Aes Sidhe (Shee). The name means 'people of the Hills, for it was believed that these people withdrew from the mortal realm and hid themselves in the 'hollow hills' or within the ancient mounds once sacred to them.

Tolkien, as in Celtic legends, has remnant populations of these immortals in all manner of hiding places: enchanted forests (like Lothlorien), hidden valleys (like Rivendell), caves, river gorges and on distant islands.

Elven time is very different from mortal time. and when Tolkien's mortal adventurers pass thru an Elven realm they experience a jolt in time. Sometimes mistaking hours for years, or years for hours.

Tolkien follows the Celtic tradition that suggests that immortals cannot survive in a mortal world; their powers diminish and ultimately there is a choice between remaining in the mortal world or leaving it forever for an immortal world.

The degree to which Tolkien's Elves were inspired by Celtic models is most obviously demonstrated by looking at his invented Elvish language, Sindarin. Tolkien noted that his invented language and Elvish names of persons and places were 'mainly' deliberately modelled on those of the Welsh. Structurally and phonetically, there are strong links between the two languages.

Tolkien took the sketchy myths and legends of the Sidhe and the Tuatha De Danann and created a vast civilization, history and geneology for his Elves. He gave them languages and a vast cultural inheritance rooted in real history but flourishing in his imagination.

The Celtic traditions of the Sidhe are all to be found in Tolkien's Elves.

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What Tolkien wanted to restore to Britain was the 'lost mythology' and literature of Anglo-Saxon Britain between the time of the Roman retreat in 419 AD and the Norman conquest in 1066 AD. With the notable exception of Beowulf and a handful of poem fragments, the ruthless obliteration of Anglo-Saxon culture by the Normans was nearly absolute.

In his imaginative writing, Tolkien wished to retrieve something of the atmosphere of that lost age of heroes and dragons so we see Anglo-saxon elements playing a critical part in his writing.

One sees this in his language and names. Theoden = chief of a nation, Ent = giant, Orc is demon or goblin in old english, Hobbit is from invented old english "holbytla, or hole builder.

BEOWULF: is an Anglo-Saxon attempt to rival the greatness of the Volsung saga. How do we know this? Because the bard first sings of Sigurd (calling him Sigmund), the greatest of all heroes and dragonslayer. Beowulf will win comparable fame by also slaying a dragon.

Tolkien was an authority on Beowulf and has acknowledged that "Beowulf is among my most valued sources' for his Hobbit tale. This is especially true of the slaying of Smaug and the episode in Beowulf. In both cases, the dragon is enraged by the theft of a cup by a thief from his treasure hoard.

Both thieves escape detection, and in both cases the nearby human settlements suffer terribly from the dragon's wrath. The respective champions, Beowulf and Bard, the Bowman, manage to slay the dragon. Bard survives, but Beowulf doesn't.

Beowulf's death is mirrored in *The Hobbit* not by Bard, but by the other warrior king, The Dwarf Thorin Oakenshield, who lives long enough to know that he has been victorious, but dies of his wounds on the battlefield.

FRODO is named after a character in Beowulf, Froda, Lord of the Bards. In his description of the mead hall, the horsemen of Rohan, the gold-roofed feast hall of King Theoden are all taken from Beowulf, which were mortal versions of the God Odin's titanic gold roofed hall Valhalla.

OTHER ANGLO SAXON SOURCES:

Other anglo-saxon tales made contributions to the Ring Trilogy also. The Saxon hero, Wayland the Smithy, which were popular in the middle ages. He was the greatest craftsman of his race.

In the Middle Ages it became traditional for the swords of great heroes to come from the forge of Wayland the Smith. Even Charlemagne's sword came from Wayland's forge.

In Wayland the Smith, we have the figure of the gifted but cursed smith who in Tolkien is manifest in Noldor King Fëanor, who made the Silmarils that were stolen by Morgoth. He is also comparable to Telchar the Dwarf smith who forged the sword inherited by Aragorn with which Elendil cuts the One Ring from Saruman's hand.

More particularly though we can see in the tale of "Wayland's Ring" something of the figure of Celebrimbor, Lord of the Elven smiths of Eregion, who forged the Rings of Power.

THE TALE OF WAYLAND'S RING:

Wayland, known as Volund in the version that has come down, begins by winning a Valkyrie wife who, in the form of a swan, Volund captures by taking her plumage. They marry, but after 9 years she finds where the plumage was hidden and flees the mortal world. However, as token of her love for him, she leaves Volund a magical ring of the purest gold.

With the ring, Volund's skills increase dramatically. He produces amazing armor and weapons, especially swords. His own sword can never be blunted or broken and anyone who holds it cannot be defeated in battle.

The ring is a source of untold wealth. Pounding it on his anvil, it produces 700 gold rings of equal weight. The king of Sweden, captures Volund and makes him his slave. He is hamstrung, exiled to a rocky isle and forced to make jewels, ornaments, weapons for the king.

After many years, he kills the king's sons, violates his daughter and regains his sword and ring. He makes wings and flies out of his island prison to Alfhiem, the Land of the Elves, where live the finest Smiths in creation. However, Volund is welcomed as a peer.

He fashions many miraculous works for gods and heroes, greater than any he made in the world of men.

In the most common version of the myth, the ring is stolen from Volund by a mortal pirate, Sote the outlaw who becomes obsessed with it. Fearful that it will be stolen, he flees to a hollow barrow grave where he never sleeps and becomes a haunted and possessed spirit by the power of the ring.

He becomes an immortal ring-wraith, one of the living dead called Barrow wights who haunt graves. Thorsten, a hero, finally wrests the ring from Sote after bitter fighting.

The latter part of the tale of Volund's ring is a major source for Tolkien for his Hobbits' near fatal encounter with the barrow wights. The difference is that although the barrow wights had their own treasure, it was Frodo who possessed the ring.

With the figure of Sote and the barrow wight spirits we see the concept of a ring that gives mortals immortality and fiendish powers but which also enslaves them and destroys their human souls.

In Sote's paranoid, goulish behaviour after he steals the ring, we also perceive something of the character of Smeagol Gollum. For after Gollum murders his cousin and steals the One Ring, like Sote he becomes obsessed with this 'precious' ring and in a kind of miserly madness he also buries himself alive.

In the foul tunnels of an abandoned Orc hold beneath the hills, Gollum hides and murders any who dare to come near, for fear that they might steal his "Precious."

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CHARLEMAGNE:

Tolkien pointed out how many readers saw the connection between Aruthur and Aragorn, but few seemed to see the connection with Charlemagne. Aragorn's great task of forging the reunited kingdom of Arnor and Gondor from the ruins of the ancient Dunedain empire after more than a millennium of chaos was historically parallel to Charlemagne's task of creating the Holy Roman Empire from the ruins of the ancient Roman empire.

Geographically the extent of the reunited kingdom of his epic far more closely paralleled the expanse of Charlemagne's realm. Tolkien suggested in a letter written in 1967, "the progress of the tale ends in what is far more like the re-establishment of an effective Holy Roman Empire with its seat in Rome.' The parallel is fairly obvious.

It is Charlemagne above all the warrior-kings of Europe who is generally credited with being the most forceful destroyer of the cult of Odin, and his germanic equivalent, Woden. He brutally suppressed all non-Christian worship. He destroyed heathen temples, burned the sacred groves and forced conversion by the sword.

In Spain he stopped forever the advance of the Saracens. He turned back the tide of Islam and put the worshippers of the prophet Mohammed to the sword. In *The Lord of the Rings* Aragorn has a similar subduing effect on all worshippers of Sauron. Some other parallels are, both carry magical, ancestral swords, (Charlemagne's sword was Joyeuse,) both have the power to cure with magical herbs, (Aragorn used 'athelas' to cure those struck by the Black breath of the Nazgul and Charlemagne used sowthistle to cure those struck by the Black Death. They only worked in the hands of the kings.) both have wise old mentors (In Charlemagne's christianized tales, the Wizard figure is replaced by an elderly

churchman, Bishop Turpin but is the same white bearded wise old mentor with a Bishops crook instead of wizard's staff.) and both married elf queens.

(Charlemagne married an exotic oriental Elf princess Frastrada) Naturally both women were considered the most beautiful women in the world.

THE SERPENT'S RING

The most compelling of the Ring legends is the tale that concerns Charlemagne's marriage to Frastrada and is called, "The Serpent's Ring". This story relate to the enslaving power of the ring and the moral stance in the rejection of the rings power. It shows how a pagan ring can still retain power in the christian era to overcome even the most devout hero, the Holy Roman Emperor.

At the wedding feast for Charlemagne and Frastrada a snake slithers into the hall with a gold ring in its mouth, drops it into the goblet of the emperor, turns and slithers out.

Believing this is a good omen, Charlemagne places the ring on the hand of his new queen. It is a ring of enchantment that begins to work. Charlemagne's love for Frastrada doubles, and redoubles. It becomes compulsive, almost unbearable. Never can he bear to be parted from one who has it upon his or her hand.

Things go well till Frastrada dies of a disease that even Charlemagne can't fix. Yet, when she dies, the power of the ring does not abate. He refuses to have her buried and he begins wasting away as he watches over her day and night.

Bishop Turpin comes to the room while Charlemagne is in fitful sleep. Like Gandalf who first recognizes the power of the One Ring, Turpin recognizes the power of the Serpent ring.

Wanting to free Charlemagne from the ring's spell, Turpin removes it from the Queen's hand and flees the chamber. When the emperor awakens, he is no longer in savage grief and allows her body to be entombed.

Now Charlemagne feels he had never before realized how important the elderly advisor was and seems to him he can only have meaning and purpose in his life with the friendship of the Bishop.

Turpin realizes the power the ring has is gender neutral but uses this to get Charlemagne to restore his own health and encourage him to attend affairs of his realm.

Turpin, like Frodo, realizes he must reject the power of the ring as it becomes too much of a burden. However, the old bishop mistrusts its sorcerous power and is fearful lest the ring fall into evil hands. He knows the Emperor will be enslaved to anyone who puts it on.

He secretly creeps away to the wilderness and looks for a way of disposing of the ring. He finds a remote lake in a forest and throws the ring into it water in his attempt to neutralize its power. To his great relief, he found that Charlemagne's infatuation for him has diminished to the simple comradeship of old.

However, this was not the end, for the serpent's ring was not destroyed by being thrown in the lake, any more than the One Ring was destroyed when it was lost in the Anduin River. Thus the power of the serpent's ring called out to Charlemagne.

He is restless, unable to concentrate, distracted. He feels compelled to travel and roam distant woodlands. He often hunts, hoping the chase will dispel his mood.

One day he enters a particular forest where he feels compelled to go deeper where he finds the lake that Turpin had thrown the ring into. Great joy fills Charlemagne and he becomes enraptured with the lake. He wants to remain there all his life.

Thus the emperor commands that a great palace and his new court be built there. This is how Aix-la-Chapelle became the capital of Charlemagne's realm.

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